

Strategy for European Defense and Civilizational Revival

The United States views Europe as strategically and culturally vital and a necessary partner for successful global competition [1, 2]. Under the Strategy, Europe's role is to regain its strength, address its profound internal issues, and take primary responsibility for its own defense [2, 3].

Core US Interests and Relationship Goals

The overarching US foreign policy interest concerning Europe is to support allies in preserving the freedom and security of Europe while simultaneously working toward restoring Europe's civilizational self-confidence and Western identity [4].

The US wants to help Europe correct its current negative trajectory [2]. Key priorities include enabling Europe to stand on its own feet and operate as a group of aligned sovereign nations, especially by taking primary responsibility for its own defense, ensuring it is not dominated by any adversarial power [3].

The Strategy notes that transatlantic trade remains a central pillar of the global economy and American prosperity, and Europe is recognized for its robust sectors (including manufacturing, technology, and energy), scientific research, and cultural institutions [1]. The US maintains a sentimental attachment to the European continent, as well as to Britain and Ireland, viewing these countries as crucial creative, capable, confident, and democratic allies needed to establish conditions of stability and security [2].

Requirements for Defense and Burden Sharing

The days of the United States shouldering the entire global order are over, meaning wealthy and sophisticated nations in Europe must assume greater primary responsibility for their defense [5].

Specifically regarding defense spending:

- The US will insist on being treated fairly by allies, no longer tolerating "free-riding," and expects allies to spend far more of their national Gross Domestic Product (GDP) on their own defense to correct massive, decades-long imbalances [6].
- President Trump has set a new global standard with the Hague Commitment, which requires NATO countries to spend 5 percent of GDP on defense—a pledge allies have endorsed and must now meet [5].
- The Strategy prioritizes ending the perception, and preventing the reality, of NATO as a perpetually expanding alliance [3].

Addressing Europe's Internal Challenges

The Strategy identifies Europe as facing serious, deep problems that go beyond insufficient military spending and economic stagnation [7]. The US is concerned that if current trends continue, Europe may be unrecognizable in 20 years, making it questionable whether certain countries will remain reliable allies with strong economies and militaries [8].

Identified problems include:

- **Economic Decline:** Continental Europe's share of global GDP has fallen from 25 percent in 1990 to 14 percent today, partly due to national and transnational regulations that hinder creativity [7].
- **Civilizational Erosion:** The prospect of "civilizational erasure" is stark, linked to policies regarding mass migration, cratering birthrates, loss of national identities, transnational bodies undermining sovereignty, and censorship of free speech [7]. The US wants Europe to remain European, regain its self-confidence, and abandon its "failed focus on regulatory suffocation" [8].
- **Ukraine and Russia:** It is a core US interest to negotiate an expeditious cessation of hostilities in Ukraine to stabilize European economies and reestablish strategic stability with Russia [9]. The US must manage European relations with Russia diplomatically to reestablish stability across the Eurasian landmass and mitigate conflict risk [8].

Policy Focus Areas

US policy for Europe should prioritize specific actions [3]:

1. Reestablishing stability within Europe and strategic stability with Russia [3].
2. Cultivating resistance to Europe's current negative trajectory within European nations [3].
3. Opening European markets to U.S. goods and services and ensuring fair treatment of U.S. workers and businesses [3].
4. Building up the healthy nations of Central, Eastern, and Southern Europe through commercial ties, weapons sales, and political, cultural, and educational collaboration [3].
5. Encouraging Europe to combat mercantilist overcapacity, technological theft, cyber espionage, and other hostile economic practices [3].

American diplomacy will also focus on advocating for genuine democracy, freedom of expression, and unapologetic celebrations of European nations' individual character and history, supporting the growing influence of patriotic European parties [1].

Summary

Europe's required transformation can be likened to a wealthy homeowner who has long relied on a massive security guard (the US) to protect their valuable neighborhood. The Strategy demands that the homeowner not only start paying a fair share but also immediately invest in

reinforcing their own home and hiring their own security staff to resume primary responsibility for their own safety and stability, while also renovating the structural foundation (civilizational confidence) of the home itself.

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